A Facilitative Interpersonal Skills (FIS) Rating Scale

Below are the descriptions for the Facilitative Interpersonal Skills (FIS) rating items. Please use the 1–5 scale provided for each item to rate the participant's response based on the quality of communication and interpersonal interaction.

(1) **Verbal Fluency.** This item is a rating of the extent to which the participant is verbally comfortable and at-ease in communicating.
- 5 – The participant is at great ease and communicates ideas with no anxiety, reflecting a desire to "approach" the other. The verbal quality of the response may have a "melodic," rhythmical quality and is easy to follow; the response is fluent.
- 4 – The response is fluent, and there is little that is difficult to follow.
- 3 – A moderate level of verbal fluency indicates that the participant's response is conversational and mostly easy to follow.
- 2 – Fluency is disrupted by the participant's anxiety and avoidance of verbal expression. The respondent may be obviously anxious and struggling to formulate a response. At times, the communication may be choppy, even halting. [Note: Often, these are responses where the participant appears unsure of what to say and might be grasping for ideas. In some rare instances a response could represent an avoidance of the interpersonal situation through anxious rambling. It would need to be clear that the participant's ramblings are the result of anxiety over communicating with another].
- 1 – The participant has great difficulty verbalizing a response (e.g., obviously anxious, sounds shaky or timid), reflecting a clear avoidance or anxiety. The participant may lack confidence and is clearly uncertain or even difficult to follow.

(2) **Hope & Positive Expectations.** This item rates expressions of hope, optimism, and positive expectations for change.
- 5 – The participant's response expresses clear hope about the client's future and/or positive expectations about therapy outcome. In addition, for a response to be coded as a "5" there needs to be an allusion to building the client's agency as well as how the client might participate or do something that will help move toward his/her desired goals (i.e., pathways).
- 4 – A general sense of optimism about the client's situation is detected. Specifically, the participant's response is directed toward building the client's agency OR identifying pathways to meet the client's goals.
- 3 – The response is ordinary OR the optimism of the response is not discernable. There may be some hopefulness expressed, but with little confidence or reason for being hopeful.
- 2 – The participant responds with some hopelessness, including subtle expressions of feeling unable to help the client.
- 1 – The participant's response is hopeless or is even pessimistic. For example, the participant may address only issues or concerns beyond the control of the other or subtly suggests that the other cannot change or improve his/her problems.

(3) **Persuasiveness.**. Persuasiveness is the capacity to induce the other to accept a view that may be different from his or her own view. It involves that ability to convey a clear, organized understanding about the meaning of the other's source of distress. Persuasiveness implies an ability to communicate what Jerome Frank called a "believable myth." This capacity implies that the persuasive therapist must be convincing in communicating this belief-system.
- 5 – The participant is highly persuasive. Persuasive persons may speak with great confidence, certainty, and authority. Advice may or may not be given, but the participant must offer some rationale or re-framing of the other's experience.
- 4 – The participant speaks persuasively. The rationale may be more implicit and it is even possible that the rationale, though present, may be unclear, superficial, or marginally relevant to the other's problems.
- 3 – The participant's response conveys little sense of persuasiveness.
- 2 – The participant is unpersuasive. Unpersuasive responses may be characterized by either
  - a rationale that lacks credibility and there is little reason to believe that it could be convincing. It is important here to try to be aware of your personal biases in judging credibility. As a rule, you can accept most explanations offered as being credible unless there is a clear logical flaw in the process of explaining their particular belief.
  - a response that is expressed with a lack of confidence, lethargy, or uncertainty by the respondent will be low in persuasiveness. Even responses that don't contain a rationale may be coded as low in persuasiveness
- 1 – The participant's response is unorganized, incoherent, and difficult to follow. The participant may also not know what to say.

(4) **Emotional Expression.** This item rates the energy and emotion in the participant's response. This item rates the extent to which the participant's response is delivered with effective expressions of emotion.
- 5 – There is affect and prosody in the participant's voice. The response is delivered in a highly emotional and engaging manner. The primary criterion is that the vocal expression conveys emotion. There may be a more focused delivery of emotional intonations to emphasize meanings that influence other processes (e.g. persuasion). The participant may even be somewhat provocative or challenging in delivering an emotion-based response toward the client in the video clip. However, a "5" should not be rated if the affect is primarily demeaning or hostile toward the other (in which case a "3" would be the maximum rating possible).
- 4 – The participant is emotionally expressive at a moderate level. There is more emotion than found in ordinary speech, but it is not as focused in its delivery as the maximum rating of 5.
- 3 – The participant has prosody, but it is the amount of emotion that one might find in ordinary conversation.
- 2 – The participant may display some sense of interest or curiosity, but the response is not emotionally engaging. Prosody is somewhat less than typical to casual conversation.
- 1 – The participant speaks with little or no affect and may be dull or boring (e.g., speaking in a near monotone voice and without intensity).

(5) **Warmth, Acceptance, & Understanding.** This item is a rating of the ability of the participant to care for and accept the other. Therapist behaviors/attitudes that might indicate an absence of acceptance and understanding include: a judgmental attitude, condescension, rudeness, disapproval, guilt-induction, exasperation, or annoyance.
- 5 – The participant expresses clear and obvious warmth, concern and acceptance. The participant may, for example, make a compassionate attempt to relate to the other's experience.
- 4 – The participant's response is genuinely nonjudgmental and gently explores the other's thoughts, feelings, alternatives for dealing with future situations, etc. The participant appears concerned for and respectful of the client.
- 3 – There is an "ordinary" level of courtesy and warmth in the response OR the participant's opinion of the other may not be clearly discernable from the response.
- 2 – The participant conveys a subtle lack of respect, acceptance, or concern of the other (e.g., sarcasm, exasperation, annoyance).
- 1 – The participant has an obvious lack of respect, acceptance, or warmth for the other (e.g., clearly pejorative comments, judgmental attitude, condescension, disapproval, guilt induction, blaming the other).

(6) **Empathy.** The capacity to respond with an expressed understanding of the subjective experience of the client. The response must also convey an accurate understanding of the thoughts and emotions expressed in the video clip.
- 5 – Participant alludes to the client's experience so that it is clear that he/she has not only listened, but obtained an exceptional comprehension of what the other is experiencing. In order to receive a "5" the participant must infer something about the other's experience that is not explicitly stated by the other but is clearly identifiable in the client's nonverbal expression.
- 4 – Participant comments accurately on the other's experience but not to the extent required to receive a "5" rating. The distinction between the 4 and 5 ratings are matters of intensity.
- 3 – Participant is generally accurate about the other's experience but only perceives the more obvious aspects of the other's experience or concerns.
- 2 – Participant does not communicate an awareness or understanding of the other's experience, and/or there are minor distortions of the other's experience. Some aspects of the participant's response may be irrelevant to the other's concerns (when clearly not an attempt to change the other's focus).
- 1 – Participant clearly distorts the other's experience. That is, the participant misidentifies a significant component of the other's complaints, beliefs, emotions, etc. Give a rating of 1 if the response indicates a clear disregard of the other's experience.

(7) **Alliance Bond Capacity.** This item rates the participant's capacity to provide a collaborative environment, one in which there is recognition of the need to work with the client jointly on problems.
- 5 – Specific actions on the part of the participant help create a collaborative atmosphere. There should be a sense that the participant is attempting to work with the other to create a "we-ness" that is implied in the participant's behavior (e.g., participant checks with the other by asking questions about the "fit" of interpretations, conclusions, goals, etc.).
- 4 – Some effort to collaborate is made but not as strong as a "5" (e.g., subtle invitations to engage in working with the client).
- 3 – The participant neither undermines nor attempts to enhance a collaborative effort.
- 2 – The participant may slightly undermine the building of a collaborative atmosphere, although it may be unintentional or superficial.
- 1 – The participant actively undermines a mutual collaboration. The participant may respond in a way that is over-involved or reactive (e.g., moralistic lecturing, "preaching" to the other, assuming all responsibility). The rupture may also involve withdrawal or under-involvement in the participant's response (e.g., putting all the responsibility for change on the other).

(8) **Alliance Rupture-Repair Responsiveness.** This item rates the extent to which the therapist appears responsive to the interpersonal issue.
- 5 – Participant makes attempts repair the interpersonal issue by engaging the client in a direct discussion of the immediate moment-to-moment interaction. This may include how specific relational messages are being expressed by the client in the video clip. Optimal responses will include attempts to not only allude to the interpersonal tension, but make some attempt to repair that interpersonal issue.
- 4 – Participant recognizes the other's interpersonal issue, and may discuss this further in more general terms (or discuss some secondary element of the others issue or the relationship).
- 3 – There may be more casual recognition of the interpersonal situation, but the response does not draw for further discussion of the issue or the relationship.
- 2 – Participant addresses an issue to discuss that it is tangentially related to the interpersonal issue presented, but directs the discussion away from the present relationship situation.
- 1 – Participant reacts to the interpersonal tension in a way that is nonproductive or in a way that likely exacerbates the rupture (e.g., responding negatively to a hostile client; responding to a controlling client with counter-control). Low scores also may be given when the participant fails to respond to the interpersonal issue involved in a way that indicates that the participant is avoiding the interpersonal issue or the relationship altogether.